DEFENDER GUIDE TO CAREERS

Achieve your career ambitions and find fulfillment through helping others

16Personalities

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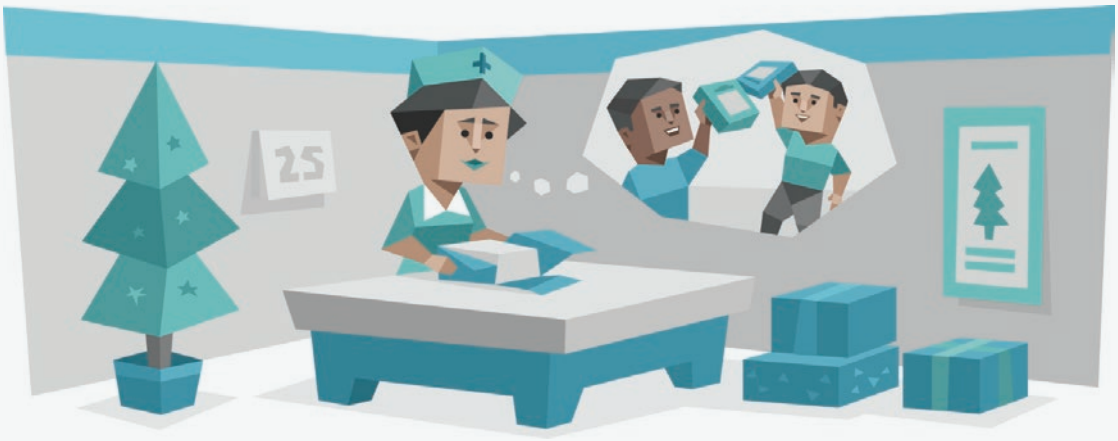

Introduction

Why Academic and Professional Development Matter for Defenders

Fame, riches, recognition – these are *not* the goals that get Defenders out of bed in the morning. What people with this personality type crave instead is the satisfaction of being useful in the world. In their daily lives, Defenders find all sorts of ways to help and uplift their loved ones and their communities, and they tend to gravitate toward careers that offer a similar sense of fulfillment through being of service.

While Defenders may not be fighting over prestigious job titles or eye-wateringly high salaries, it would be a mistake to think of them as without ambition. Hardworking and diligent, Defenders strive to be capable, collaborative, knowledgeable, and reliable. Wherever they find themselves, they want to do their absolute best. And while they're generally happy to work behind the scenes, they light up inside when a colleague, boss, client, or teacher recognizes their contributions.

From the early days of their schooling, Defenders want to set a sturdy foundation for their learning that will enable them to contribute to the world. People with this personality type don't feel particularly gratified by getting the correct answers through strokes of luck or inspiration. Instead, they want to understand the right way to solve problems so that they can consistently and reliably find their way to the correct answers. For Defenders, schooling isn't about squeaking through but rather about gaining important skills that they can carry onward with them. This attitude carries through to their professional lives – rather than showing off, Defenders work to master the fundamentals of their

trade so that they can reliably deliver on tasks and, with time, become the colleague everyone else can trust and depend on.

Defenders' hard work and dedication often pay off, both in the classroom and in the workplace. But even the steadiest of Defenders can become demoralized when their efforts don't yield results, when big changes threaten to derail their preferred way of doing things, or when the people around them take advantage of their willingness to pitch in. In these pages, we'll discuss how Defenders can bring the full strength of their gifts to their schooling and their careers – all while working through the challenges and frustrations that tend to arise for people with this personality type.

Curious about the traits that make up your personality type and the theory behind them? You can learn more here.

Academic Path

Defenders learn best in environments that apply the following three principles: practicality, duty, and tradition. As students, they're most comfortable in traditional classrooms with traditional teaching methods. They prefer "how-to" experiences in the classroom – "How to Fix a Flat Tire," or "How to Pay Taxes," or "How to Administer CPR" – real, concrete lessons that can aid them in everyday life.

How Defenders Learn

Naturally dutiful, these types seek out knowledge paths to use in helping their community and loved ones. One of their primary motivations is to be of service, offering mutual support and, on occasion, guidance. Take, for example, math-savvy Defenders who take time out of their day to help their younger siblings learn the intricacies of multiplication.

Tradition is important to these types, not so much in the conservative sense, but that they follow what their community and family tell them is safe, stable, and effective. Knowing what they're learning in the academic realm can later help create a stable future is enough for Defenders. However, they sometimes don't realize that there are choices outside those expectations.

The abstract and theoretical are of little interest to these pragmatic people. This isn't to say they don't engage in topics like philosophy and art, but if there's no need for real-world application, then Defenders rarely see the point in their learning about them. They tend to tolerate the theoretical only if the lesson ties the idea to something practical. If

a debate or lecture doesn't land on something useful, they're likely to see the whole experience as "going around in circles."

Sentinels are very detail-oriented, and Defenders are particularly so. They don't mind routine and repetitive tasks when there's a specified end goal. For example, Defenders who specialize in music have no issue with practicing a complicated piece one hundred times, so long as they get it right in the end. It isn't uncommon to perceive Defenders as "model students," as they're likely to do what's asked of them and do it correctly.

It tends to be *very* difficult to pull Defenders away from their routines and areas of comfort. Once these types believe something, it can be hard for them to accept alternative ideas. This may also factor into why Defenders are known as the "most loyal" of the types, for better or for worse. Their trademark commitment to their long-held beliefs may make it difficult for them to excel in courses that rely on imagination and creativity. They tend to shy away from general class discussions where there can be too many radical ideas flying about.

Instructors can tap into Defender students' strengths by providing them with a sense that they're doing something, and not just spinning their wheels in the mud. The optimal learning environment for these types looks like this:

- A subject that's taught in a systematic, linear fashion
- Hands-on training
- A model that can be copied and referred to if additional coaching is needed
- Ideas that connect the past to the present
- Proven conventional ideas linked to a concrete purpose
- Constructive, objective feedback
- Affirmed hierarchy

For example: Defenders' teachers should be teachers, and not trying to be best friends with their students.

Defenders, while naturally hard workers, find it challenging and uncomfortable to excel in environments where:

- New ideas come apparently "out of nowhere," and are allowed to run wild
- Classrooms where teachers allow things to be too relaxed
- Unspecified goal objectives
- Being put on the spot or asked to give opinions before the material's been learned

These types need to be sure of themselves and prefer to be confident in their answers before they commit to them. Defenders always appreciate a reasonable amount of time to check their work before they respond.

Despite the above, these students always work to deliver reliable results. They strive to be good students, no matter how uncomfortable they may feel. While it may be healthy for Defenders to step outside of their comfort zones and relax a bit, they can rest easy knowing that today's education system rewards students like them.

Balanced Learning Habits

Community-Based Pragmatism

Defenders learn for the sake of their local community and loved ones. These gentle types take pride in their homes and hearths and tend to do what's needed to maintain a safe future. Defenders build upon the foundation of their inner circles and help mend fences where they can.

They'll likely learn what's necessary to fill an existing gap or follow a path that those immediately around them have deemed acceptable – pursuing a nursing degree because they come from a long line of nurses, for example. Academically speaking, Defenders draw energy and enthusiasm from knowing that whatever they're learning also pleases the ones closest to them.

A Strict Work Ethic

Defenders strive to do their best because it's expected of them. Even if they dislike a subject, not giving 100% is unimaginable for these students. Defenders hate the idea of not fulfilling their commitments and obligations (even if they didn't ask for them). They don't take deadlines lightly and tend to complete others' tasks if needed to bring a project in on time.

This work ethic extends beyond a sense of obligation to others, however. Defenders work hard to form a stable set of guiding principles for how they live their lives. It's a point of pride that they're able to do what they do, whether it's staying up all night to study (for better or worse) or seeing a degree program to the end.

Unbalanced Learning Habits

Obligation Over Opportunity

Safety and security are of the utmost importance for Defenders. They learn what they learn because they know that whatever lies at the end of the tunnel likely leads to a stable life. The idea of change, or the thought of an unknown path – studying art without a clear career destination, for example – can create huge amounts of anxiety and stress for these usually sure-footed people.

These types tend to study out of a sense of obligation without knowing where their particular paths may lead. If they know that they're expected to go to college, then they do so. Unfortunately, this can also rob them of the opportunity to explore other options in a healthy manner. They may pick a field of study and commit to it because they may not know what else to do, and then refuse to change majors even if better options reveal themselves.

Expectation Overload

When people are struggling, they can count on Defenders to help show them the way (even if it's a detriment to Defenders themselves). These types often pick up the slack of unwilling classmates and colleagues, not necessarily because they want to, but because they believe it's expected of them.

These types may also have a hard time veering from paths dictated by loved ones and overload themselves with other's expectations. Take, for example, going to a specific university because it was their parents' alma mater, *not* because they enjoy being there. It's far too easy for Defenders to overload themselves – or to be overloaded by others – as they silently struggle to meet everyone's expectations.

Rebalancing Learning Habits

Venturing Out of the Comfort Zone

Comfort may be what we all strive for, but it can also be what holds Defenders back from life's great adventure. While they don't need to bound out of the Shire and fight dragons (as fictional Defender Bilbo Baggins did in *The Lord of the Rings*), they can practice small steps toward venturing out of their comfort zones.

Many seek out the comfort of routine for its low stress and predictability. Making a change is easier said than done, especially if Defenders don't know what the outcome may be. This is part of the reason why these types don't appreciate being put on the spot. Here are some things they can keep in mind to help keep them going.

- When Defenders break out of their comfort zone – even just a little – they can find increased productivity, an expansion of boundaries, and life-changing experiences. All of these are important to creating a well-rounded individual.
- They can try doing something small, yet routine, differently every other week: pick a new place to study, try to read a book that usually wouldn't capture their interest, or talk to a classmate with ideas radically different than their own.
- By making changes little by little, Defenders can gather the courage to take a big leap – like going off to a university where they don't know anyone, but where the opportunities are boundless – and still manage their stress levels.

Putting Self First

"No, I can't help you," is a sentence that Defenders find very difficult to say. If they do decline to assist, they may follow up with, "I can help

find someone who can help you," or, "I can help you later." Rarely do Defenders flat out say, "No," even if providing guidance results in some internal grumbling on their part.

While their patience and tolerance for others are two of their best traits, they can also be points of stress. Unhealthy Defenders tend to go out of their way to meet the expectations of those around them, completely ignoring their own desires in the process. (In more extreme cases, they can be completely unaware of those desires.) Before they can help anyone else, they must first take care of themselves – they can't tutor classmates, take on other students' workloads, AND focus on their own studies if they're stressed to the point of breaking down.

Putting themselves first may seem, well, a bit selfish to these dutiful types. However, it's an essential skill for everyone to learn, and Defenders can start by first acknowledging their own desires – not those of their parents, family, or friends, but what genuinely makes *them* happy. They can try, for example, journaling three times a week. A concrete record of their emotions and thoughts may be what they need to clarify their own needs.

Defenders in High School

Defenders are the students that teachers love. They're hardworking, dedicated to doing well, and enjoy earning good grades. While other students sulk about and complain about life, Defenders tend to flourish in the structured learning environment that is high school.

High school is more than just classes. Most would agree there are as many lessons in secondary education football fields, clubs, and hallways as there are in the classrooms. So, let's take a moment to consider high school as a place where important social lessons unfold.

Defenders are usually well-liked, but rarely "popular" in the cliched sense. They may have a group of close friends to whom they're very loyal and feel attached. However, their Introversion may make them a bit reclusive and, therefore, a bit like outsiders. Although they're inherently warm people, it may take them awhile to let new people see their warmth. Luckily, social status, or having a bevy of friends, aren't primary concerns for Defender students.

When it comes to socializing, Defenders tend to be born listeners and observers. They aren't likely to offer an opinion if they aren't asked, and are liable to be less talkative than more Extraverted types (especially amongst people they don't know well). These types play a supporting role, always present, and always there to lend a hand, but they may see little need in going beyond that.

In high school, Defenders' inherent need to meet expectations are more apparent than ever as they balance academics, societal pressure, and, unfortunately, hormones.

Balanced High School Learning Habits

Doing What Needs to Be Done

Defenders do well in courses that promote organizational prowess or skills that they can apply to everyday life – word processing, for example, and subjects they can use as a resource for existing issues. However, not enjoying a course wouldn't stop them from trying to succeed in it. Unlike Analysts or Diplomats, Defenders likely don't need to find a subject interesting or exciting to apply themselves.

These types may believe that a course is there for a reason, and it needs to be done, regardless of their personal feelings. Defenders tend to work hard from the first day of high school to the day they graduate to meet all the requirements put in front of them.

These types accomplish all necessary courses and meet reasonable expectations, but also make sure to make time or invest more in the subjects they genuinely enjoy. For example, Defenders who enjoy their chemistry class may also be active members of the after-school Chemistry Club.

Gaining Skills through Support

Defenders gravitate to the clubs they're "supposed to" belong to, whether for academic improvement, service to others, or a career path of some kind. Being practical, they tend to join clubs that pad their resumes or their college applications. They may join the Drama Club or

other performing groups if they're presented as community builders – but even then, Defenders make sure to stay out of the spotlight.

They don't enjoy the limelight and are less likely than most to become leaders of any extracurricular organizations. If they join the Drama Club, they run the lights. If they join Debate, they manage the debate schedule. With their attention to detail and affinity for protocol, they'd probably do quite well in leadership roles. However, it's more likely that they'd prefer to take a more auxiliary position, such as secretary or treasury.

Creating Bonds through Caring

One of Defenders' greatest strengths is their capacity to care. Like other Sentinels, these types tend to make it a point to care for their fellow students. It won't be about sweeping compassion as much as about making sure their friends' practical needs are met. If other students reach out for help, Defenders try to support them to the best of their ability, such as helping to tutor struggling students in a subject at which they excel.

This friendly helpfulness can go a long way to creating serious bonds of friendship in high school, giving Defenders a sense belonging even if they're never one of the "cool kids." This is likely satisfying enough for them.

Unbalanced High School Learning Habits

Doing Only What's Expected

These types are dutiful and committed, driven to meet the expectations placed upon their shoulders. While this often works in their favor, it can also turn against them when, because they're so focused on meeting requirements, they miss out on doing things they enjoy.

Finding joy in learning is vital to the academic process, and Defenders may find that they've lost this joy somewhere along the way as they struggle to meet the expectations of everyone but themselves. For example, those who study to do well on standardized tests may find they've learned nothing outside the bounds of those tests.

Defenders also run the risk of not knowing what they like or enjoy. They may never let themselves find their passion or specialize while they're still in high school, which can lead to steeper challenges later in higher education or in a career.

Rigid Responsibility

One of the challenges Defenders face in the high school classroom is that they may possess a certain rigidity. These types prefer defined structure and rules, so when faced with situations where there's no "right" answer, as in philosophy or statistics, they may become frustrated.

They also may have trouble relating to their fellow students. Frustration may be mutual if Defenders find themselves expected to work with a group of students who want to cut corners on the details of a project. They may want to follow directions to the letter while their peers don't, and for conflict-averse Defenders, this can be particularly stressful.

Being the hardworking students that they are, Defenders may be very hard on those who are slower or don't carry their own weight. On the other hand, teachers tend to value the care and attention that Defenders put into their work.

Rebalancing High School Learning Habits

Combining Patience with Assertiveness

Because teenage Defenders are relatively rule-abiding and just plain "good" compared to many of their peers, they may harbor frustration with the ruffians and slackers of their generation. It's difficult for them to fathom *wanting* to be a disruption. They may be thinking, "Why can't you just do the work?" or, "Is it so hard for you to sit quietly in class and listen?"

However, given their gentle and kind nature, Defenders seldom speak up. While they usually ignore disruptive people, what can they do if, say, they're grouped with the disrupters? Their natural approach may be to let the to let others off the hook and do the work themselves. After all,

it's so much easier than dealing with classroom agitators head on. But while this may be easier, it isn't necessarily fair to either Defenders or the offenders.

In cases where someone is a genuine annoyance, young Defenders should learn to speak up (even if it makes them intensely uncomfortable). The first step is to acknowledge that they have a right *not to* have to clean up after others. Others may see kind, gentle Defenders as "doormats." It's up to Defenders to correct this assumption – in their own gentle way, of course.

Defenders can deal with slacker classmates by channeling their pragmatic fairness, distributing the work, and holding others accountable with clear goals in mind. Below are tips that can help ease the process:

- Take the slacker aside and communicate issues with them using "I feel..." phrases.
- Be sure to stick to facts about the project they're working on: deadlines, page counts, requirements, etc.
- Build in mini-goals to the project to keep the slacker on track.

Learning to Take a Break

High school's hard. With the added pressure parents, extracurricular activities, and even the future, in general, can bring, it can be exhausting for even the laziest of people, and downright back-breaking for hardworking Defenders. These types are always looking to do their best in whatever they commit to, even at the risk of their own health.

While most teenagers would jump at the chance of staying home, young Defenders tend to be reluctant to take sick days. They prefer taking some medicine, squaring their shoulders, and going out to face a day of exams, homework, and practices. Missing a day of school can cause these types to feel nervous as they contemplate all the valuable information they're not learning.

Still, health is more important than grades. Below are some ways that Defenders may take a break or a sick day in peace.

- Ask the question: "If a friend was sick or wasn't feeling well, would I ask them to work through it?" If the answer is "No," then Defenders should consider why they would ask it of themselves.
- Don't panic. Remember, whatever information is missed during the break can be caught up.
- Try not to think about school while on break. Taking the time to rest is the surest path back to school attendance.

Beyond Expectations

Young Defenders do well in areas where expectations are clear. They're also very good at meeting the expectations of those around them – parents, mentors, friends. There's incredible pressure on these types to succeed and make those they love and admire proud. Defenders at the top of their class, and who push themselves hard, but ultimately don't know what they like beyond the established criteria are all-too-common examples of this.

Performing well is a good thing, but Defenders should also learn how to balance their responsibilities with activities they genuinely enjoy. High school is a good time to start figuring out what they like, dislike, and ultimately start to figure out who they are.

Below are some questions to find out what Defenders' personal passions may be:

- "When I was a child, I dreamed of _____."
- "Most people don't know this about me, but I really enjoy _____."
- "I am the go-to person when my friends need help with _____."

Defenders' path to finding what they genuinely enjoy may be a long one, but the nearly endless patience they provide to others should also be applied to themselves. They can attempt a new activity every other week – sit in on the Debate Club, crack open a novel they wouldn't otherwise read, or pick an unusual topic for their next assigned project.

Work or College?

Go to college? Or go into the workforce? This fork-in-the-road decision plagues all young adults as they prepare to leave the swaddling comfort of high school. While personality type isn't the only factor that goes into making this choice, it can be a significant variable.

Higher education was once the path taken to guaranteed security and success. Now, having a degree may have little to no relevance in today's competitive job market. The question many Defenders face is whether it's more practical to enter a trade in early adulthood to build their lives, or to bolster their future security by obtaining a degree.

Central to Defenders' considerations are cultural expectations, especially regarding their families. These types may find it difficult to defy a family full of college graduates, and likely choose higher education because it's expected.

However, it's important for Defenders to know that they have choices available to them. So, what are some things they can consider when making that choice?

Balanced Decision-Making

Understanding the Path

Many Defenders have already decided on the career or field they want to enter by the time their high school graduation rolls around. They could choose to go into the workforce rather than continue their education, and many of these types do just that. If this decision is made in a healthy manner, then it's based on Defenders' self-knowledge and hearty pragmatism. The career they choose is likely a practical one, as well as one in which they find satisfaction.

Defenders tend to be anything but wasteful, and the idea of potentially spending massive amounts of money and time on something that could be possibly irrelevant is painful for them to consider. Without a sense of purpose or meaning in going to college, it's likely to be a bad experience for these types.

Take, for example, the path of a web developer. Many web developers are self-taught – they've never taken a college course on coding, but

instead practiced diligently for years. Then there are web developers who are classically trained by universities. Neither has a distinct disadvantage when it comes to finding work, especially if they decide to freelance. Defenders who want to be web developers may likely choose the self-taught route, saving money and resources in the process.

Checking off the Requirements

If Defenders need a degree or a certification for their desired career – teacher, social worker, nurse, physician – then they get them. However, these types tend to keep practicality in mind as they search for institutions to provide their certifications. They're just as likely to go with the relatively economical choice of trade schools or community colleges for their degree as four-year universities.

They're likely to seriously consider their families' opinions of their college choices as well. While the weigh-ins of family members and mentors are essential to Defenders, a balanced decision should be based on how they feel about the universities they're considering.

Unbalanced Decision-Making

Fear of the Unknown

Defenders are pragmatic, grounded, and tend to fear change. The idea of leaving what they know for a virtually unknown future can be terrifying to these types, including choosing a career or choosing to go (or stay) in college.

Fear of the unknown may force Defenders into early work (say, the family business), as they see it as a system that works. They may not choose to stay necessarily because they want to, or because they enjoy their work, but because the option of going down the road not taken may seem too stressful.

On the flip side, Defenders may choose to go to college because it's the path their families have traditionally taken. Even if they prefer a specific career that doesn't require a college degree, they may not want to go against the grain. The same can be said for Defenders who don't want to *leave* college because of the ever-competitive, unpredictable

job market. They may opt to become "professional students" instead, and remain in relatively regimented academic arenas.

Selecting for Others

Defenders, always conscientious of societal expectations, may pick a route that's deemed "proper" or "acceptable" by the authority figures in their lives. It's at this point that these types may start down a path of passive living – letting powerful loved ones have the majority say in their life choices, even if they're choices that Defenders don't particularly like.

Rebalancing Decision-Making

Facing the Unknown

Defenders don't necessarily avoid change – they tend to have no problems with choosing to go into the workforce or higher education if they know what each involves. It's only when they don't know what's on the other side of these tunnels that they're likely to become nervous and, ultimately, avoidant. Facing challenges, however, creates a better-rounded and more stable person.

The key to facing the unknown is understanding that it's acceptable to fail. Defenders may have it in their minds that they can only be model students or model employees, and nothing less. And the only way to accomplish that is if they can see the path clearly before them.

While they may not always be able to see a clearly-defined path, Defenders can gain confidence when facing the unknown by practicing the following:

- Visualize future obstacles and struggles. For example, Defenders can imagine they're far away from home, away from family and friends, and they don't do so well on an exam.
- After imagining the obstacle, ask the following three questions about the hypothetical situation:
  - "What can be learned from this situation?"
  - "How is personal growth from this experience possible?"
  - "What are three possible positive things about this situation?"

By thinking through this type of perceived fear, Defenders can hopefully understand that such a failure won't destroy their academic career or their place in the workforce.

Finding Personal Value

One of Defenders' best traits is how much esteem they tend to hold their families' opinions in. But when it comes to making the landmark decision of choosing either college or work, the only opinion that should matter is their own.

When choosing, Defenders should answer the following questions with one to two sentence responses. Try to remain clear and concise as possible.

- When have they felt engaged and enthusiastic, work or academic wise?
- When did they overcome a difficult challenge successfully?
- When have they achieved peak performance?
  - What were they doing at the time?
  - What were the principles they followed?
  - What did they do to reach their goal?
  - Did they feel personally satisfied by their accomplishment?
- Bearing in mind the challenges they face now (and possibly in the future), how can they build on what they know works?

When Defenders becomes aware of what works for them, it can make choosing work or college somewhat easier.

Defenders in College

Defenders may have mixed feelings when entering college. There's an opportunity to gain some real skills and develop professional credentials. However, university life tends to have less guidance and a more unstructured environment than high school. This can be disconcerting to students with as many fixed habits and beliefs as Defenders have.

College is a time for Defenders to consider and build upon their strengths in a real way, developing competence. They need to be careful when choosing their majors. If their courses are too abstract or theoretical (philosophy and poetry, for example), they're likely to find little satisfaction. Choosing a major heavy in labs and practicums – like medicine, for instance – may suit Defenders well.

Their course choices are likely to be similar to the subjects they connected with in high school. They may do well in any detail-oriented work that needs careful administration: bookkeeping, business management, health care, education, law, social work, and religious studies come to mind. For Defenders, the subjects aren't nearly as important as their application and purpose. It's unlikely they might be attracted to less traditional courses, such as women's studies or applied artistic techniques. They instead tend to seek more bedrock courses – perhaps something their parents might have taken a generation earlier.

These types have the work ethic to do well in any niche they choose, but they're likely to wonder if they'll feel satisfied, or if they'll be of use. Some believe that college is only about gathering the tools needed to make a healthy living, and Defenders may fit into this category. However, these types always have one eye on contributing to their communities and taking care of others. Making a healthy living would more likely be about taking care of their families rather than the gratuitous accumulation of wealth.

Balanced Approach to College

Conscientious and Responsible

In high school, Defenders knew exactly where they had to be and what they had to do, but there are more opportunities for fluidity and autonomy in college. This sudden freedom can be overwhelming, which is why it's common for many first-year students to become depressed and unproductive as they try to find their new purpose in life.

Luckily, Defenders have better luck than most in adapting to this new environment. Yes, they may be away from friends and family, and yes, they're change-averse types who have been thrown wildly out of their

element. Even with all that said, Defenders tend to subconsciously look for the clearest path possible. They're likely to read their syllabi (unlike their peers). They probably won't sign up for an 8 AM class if they know it's difficult for them to wake up in the morning. They tend to do their best to turn in quality assignments when they're due.

To keep track of all their requirements and expectations, Defenders' day planners may be their best friends for the first few rocky months of higher education, but at least their diligence in studying and meeting deadlines may stave off an existential crisis when finals time comes around.

Gathering the Tools for a Good Life

Some college students want to party the next four years away, but this couldn't be further from the truth when it comes to these types. Healthy Defenders' primary reason for choosing higher education is simple – to receive the certifications or degrees required for their chosen careers. They understand the path they've embarked on, and have chosen higher education for its focused implementation of their life plans.

College can be an arena for personal exploration, but Defenders see it more as an investment in the tools needed to build a stable, steady future. They tend to be the personality type who utilizes campus resources to their fullest – career services, job fairs, their professors, and, of course, information.

Unbalanced Approach to College

The Straw that Broke the Camel's Back

Defenders are naturally inclined to overload themselves. Whether it be the pressures of academia, the needs of others, or the expectations they have for themselves, sooner or later, these types can expect to bow under the weight of it all.

In high school, their uncanny ability to stress themselves out was on a "low simmer" due to smaller workloads and fewer expectations. In college, however, Defenders have free rein to express their extreme perfectionism within their chosen courses and activities. They can also

add stress to their lives by making lofty demands of themselves, such as the following:

- Not allowing for leniency when they make mistakes.
- Pushing too hard to achieve/maintain high grades.
- Pushing too hard to meet the expectations of family members and loved ones.

As their stress levels come to a full boil, Defenders may yet continue to smile dutifully while melting beneath the oppressive heat and pressure. While their breakdowns may be quieter than those of other types, they're breakdowns nonetheless, and should be addressed immediately, not ignored (as many Defenders feel the need to do).

Rebalancing Their Approach to College

Reshaping Unreasonable Expectations

Defenders in college may be unwilling to deal with the root of their stress – meeting unreasonable expectations. If the expectations of their loved ones include maintaining a perfect grade point average while taking a full course load of rigorous classes and holding down a part-time job, then it's safe to say that these expectations can be a little unreasonable.

Defenders are incredibly patient people and apply pragmatic fairness when they can. If friends were to come to them and vent about the same stresses listed above, they wouldn't tell them it's their fault. They'd listen, perhaps say they're dealing with a hard situation, and point out that all they can do is try their best. Funnily enough, they're reluctant to say the same things to themselves. Here are some truths these types should keep in mind.

- The first step to dealing with the issue of heavy expectations is to first acknowledge that they're unreasonable. A simple way to check if they're unreasonable is to ask the question, "Would I ask someone else to do all these things?"
- These types are prone to suffering in silence, not wanting to bother those around them with what they may consider to be petty worries.

Defenders grit their teeth and bear the pain, sometimes ignoring their emotions completely. However, to be better-rounded people, it's necessary to understand that it's okay not to be okay.

- Defenders can combat these self-blaming tendencies by practicing self-compassion exercises. These can range from composing a self-compassion letter to taking self-compassion "breaks," if their focus is giving Defenders the room they need to breathe and stop mistreating themselves.

Lifelong Learning

For Defenders, "learning" is very much about gaining relevant "real world" skills. They gather what they need to create and maintain a stable life and better serve the people and organizations they care about. This is why they acknowledge formal education as a resource, and, to a lesser degree, are aware of its ability for personal development.

As they mature, Defenders may find what they consider necessary – home, family, work – tends to expand to include things like learning how to garden so they can grow their own vegetables for meals, or how to have better relationships with their children, or to be more productive at work. Other Defenders, however, may continue treading the same well-worn paths. They may stubbornly insist that, while they haven't learned everything there is to know, they at least know what they need to get by.

However, it should be noted that Defenders are aware there's always something new to learn and apply. For example, registered nurses are asked to update their knowledge of new medical procedures, guidelines, and innovations every year. In cases like this, Defenders tend to be more than happy to take tests and courses for the rest of their lives.

Balanced Lifelong Learning

Having Time to Learn

Defenders often find that as they get older, their obligations grow more numerous. It can be effortless for these types to become completely

swept up by the expectations of relationships, family, work, and the organizations in which they're invested. However, well-rounded Defenders understand that a balanced life includes having time for themselves as well.

While work and personal obligations are necessary, there's *always* room to incorporate new skills into their everyday routine, and they can make it a point to carve out time in their busy lives to indulge in learning skills they enjoy. For example, those who want to learn how to cook intricate recipes won't necessarily join a cooking class, but can try to make a new meal once a week with their family.

Learning New Skills to Complement Old Lives

Defenders don't acquire new skills for novelty's sake. They take the time to look at the life they currently have, and look for ways to enrich it for both themselves and the ones they care about. This can manifest in things like learning more about automobiles to handle minor car issues on their own, or taking up carpentry to create simple furniture pieces they can then pass on to their children.

On the topic of formal education, Defenders may be open to pursuing more certifications and higher-level degrees if doing so improves their career prospects. However, Defenders tend to be content in their jobs if they provide steadily for their lives. Anything more would seem gratuitous.

Unbalanced Lifelong Learning

Settling and Stagnant

While easily content, these types may also settle into a lifestyle merely because they're afraid of change. This fear is apparent in all Sentinels, but in Defenders most of all. They may try to convince themselves that they're just not cut out for a different path, and that everyone who's followed it is far braver (or foolish) than they are.

Defenders cling to stability because the chance of failing is distinctly lower if the road ahead is already clear. However, if these types are unwilling to step away from what they know, if even for a moment, it

may hinder their growth. That same place may be comfortable, but it may also be keeping them from more suitable opportunities.

This line of thinking may also lead Defenders to believe that there's nothing else for them to learn – and even if there are new things to learn, it could hardly be worth the effort to go outside of their comfort zones.

No Time for Learning

Defenders' inclination to be of service to their loved ones and their communities means they can quickly lose themselves to day-to-day tasks, and often those tasks aren't reserved for themselves.

When they allow every moment of their day to be dictated by obligations and expectations – doing their best at work, being model employees, making sure their partners and kids are satisfied, making sure their parents are happy, that the bills are paid, that the house is clean, and a thousand other little things – they could be missing out on vital personal development time. It's possible that years may pass by with Defenders not learning about anything they're personally interested in.

Rebalancing Lifelong Learning

Varying the Routine

"Being set in your ways" isn't necessarily a bad thing. However, there's always room for improving upon an existing routine. Here are some ideas Defenders can use to do just that.

- Defenders can start with a relatively mundane task, such as a walk. Rather than taking the same path every day, these types can choose a different route every other week: a walk through a forest trail, a walk through the city, a different route through the neighborhood.
- Based on these small excursions, Defenders can then adjust their routines based on what they enjoyed about the experiences – or they may not change their old habits at all if they suited them best.
- The important thing is that they've gained the basis for comparison to make more well-informed decisions.

Conclusion

Inspired Learning

Time may be the biggest obstacle in Defenders' academic development. There may be other obligations distracting them from learning more about the things they enjoy. However, it's important for these types to carve out time for themselves, and to put themselves first every so often. Creating space for self-care can help lower stress and improve Defenders' overall mood.

Committing at least an hour a day to learning or practicing a skill they enjoy can be incorporated into their everyday routines. Take, for example, Defenders who like to relax by watching television for a couple of hours at night. They can also use this time to practice knitting or sewing (given they take an additional hour or two to learn the technique). Instead of being "on call" for those they love all the time, they can kindly refuse events or requests from others, and instead, take that time attend a class on coding that they've always wanted to try. Devoted as they are to helping others grow, Defenders putting their needs first every so often can find it a positive step toward their own personal growth.

Professional Development

Defenders are one of the most prevalent personality types, which is great news for employers as they're some of the most reliable, dependable, and hardworking individuals. The list of typical Defender careers is probably the longest amongst all personality types – and for very good reason. They tend to be very altruistic and well-rounded individuals, making them excellent employees.

Throughout this section, we'll discuss how Defenders can maintain balance and excel in their professional development with a better understanding of their traits. We'll look at what may cause them to become frustrated and unbalanced in these areas, and how they can utilize their strengths to regain their balance and thrive in their professional growth. Ultimately, we hope this guide gives Defenders the understanding and tools needed to pursue their ideal career path.

Ideal Employees at Every Level

Reliable? Of course. Devoted? Undoubtedly. Punctual? Absolutely. Compassionate? That, too! One of the best things about Defenders is that they're practical and yet still incredibly well-rounded. Like other Sentinels, these types are unstoppable on the job once they find a niche where they can contribute to the good of the organization while maintaining their stability and security.

People with this personality type believe in the significance of facts and duties, yet they prioritize the human component of their work. Consequently, the best careers for Defenders tend to reward their meticulousness and dedication while still promoting positive human

contact. These types have very high standards, especially when it comes to their own work, and are likely to put in an extraordinary amount of effort to get the job done – even when they know that their efforts may go unrecognized. While they appreciate recognition, Defenders' internal motivation to do the "right thing" is more important than any reward or acknowledgment.

Another way Defenders excel in the workplace is through their ability to gather and remember various facts, especially about other people. This is a great social skill in most career paths, particularly when teamwork and cooperation are necessary. Devoted Defenders tend to always remember the name of their boss's daughter or their colleagues' birthdays. Furthermore, they're very much aware of other people's emotions. Their skill set ensures they're excellent employees at every level, from subordinate to manager.

Humble and Loyal Servants

Defenders are probably the most unpretentious personality type of them all. Service-oriented and warm, their respect for traditional values and security is usually reflected in the careers to which they're drawn. Defenders tend to be excellent nurses and social or religious workers, as these jobs allow them to tap into their desire to serve others while engaging in meaningful occupations. It isn't uncommon to see these types also involved in volunteer activities in their communities.

They seek work behind the scenes, causing their quiet resilience and determination to often go unnoticed. A lack of appreciation for their tireless work doesn't deter them from their mission, however, as they're driven by their sense of responsibility and a desire for stability. This isn't to say that Defenders prefer to work without recognition, but, rather, that their focus is on making sure that the job gets done and everyone's needs get met – even at the expense of their own desires.

With their focus on responsibility comes a deep sense of devotion. Once Defenders commit to their chosen careers or companies, they tend to display a peerless sense of loyalty. Most individuals with this personality type are looking for long-term "relationships" – careers with companies they can work for as long as they want. Devotion, loyalty, and a need for security and stability make these types ideal long-term hires.

Selectively Social

While they love helping others and are often drawn toward careers where they can engage in caretaking roles, Defenders are still Introverts. And, like other Introverted types, they tend to be relatively quiet, introspective, and prone to becoming overwhelmed by excessive, or aggressive, social interaction, such as high-pressure sales jobs. Socialization must have a purpose, and even their camaraderie with colleagues may not necessarily translate into friendships outside of the workplace.

Defenders are brilliant administrators, safe keepers, logisticians, and caretakers who do their best work individually or in small teams. As they prefer to work behind the scenes, they're often glad to accept someone else's authority and leadership, if that individual doesn't break any rules or procedures and treats others with respect and dignity. This doesn't mean that Defenders don't make terrific team leaders, just that they aren't necessarily seeking leadership roles, power, or attention in a career.

These types may also find themselves lacking social support, often because they give the appearance of being unbreakable. Their ability to take on a seemingly insurmountable array of tasks without faltering in their duties creates the impression that they don't need help. Being caretakers themselves, these types are also hesitant to ask anyone else to assist them with their work. They don't want to be a burden to others.

Overly Practical Perfectionists

Defenders are very practical and may find more satisfaction in careers that avoid a theoretical or abstract focus, such as leading academic research or brainstorming product development. They're at their best when implementing plans and making things work (a crucial role in most companies), as opposed to spending significant amounts of time generating new ideas.

These types may struggle in positions where they're expected to deal with ambiguous or abstract information. A lack of defined timelines or clear expectations can frustrate Defenders enormously. Structure and order are necessary for them to feel comfortable and productive.

Additionally, Defenders don't fare well in situations where they need to do unfamiliar work under time constraints. While they're decisive and able to keep a cool head in critical situations, they feel far more comfortable when they've enough time to assess situations and make informed decisions. Defenders have excellent problem-solving skills lurking beneath the surface, but being in "emergency mode" can exhaust them very quickly.

Making a Point to Build a Support System

One of the most important things Defenders can do to improve the quality of both their work and their relationships is to create solid support systems. It's not necessary to befriend every employee or customer. Most Defenders, however, may benefit from building relationships with at least a couple of trusted coworkers. Having allies in the workplace – especially those who express appreciation and recognition – can increase Defenders' morale even in the most difficult or stressful work environments.

Building relationships with coworkers can be intimidating, especially for Introverted types, but Defenders' loyalty, devotion, and compassion tends to make them respected, sought-after friends. The best way to attract chums in the workplace is to abide by the adage, "Treat others how you would like to be treated." Expressing gratitude for help received and acknowledging hard work and positive results that others achieve are fantastic ways to garner goodwill.

Practicing Flexibility

Consistency, an essential skill that many Defenders share, is incredibly valuable. However, people with this personality type may benefit from learning to be more flexible when it comes to their expectations. People are never going to behave exactly as others think they should, and situations are never going to be ideal. Defenders can work on finding specific ways to deal with these issues instead of struggling with them.

When it comes to dealing with coworkers, customers, patients, or students, Defenders may benefit from finding trusted friends, family members, or colleagues to use as sounding boards. These types may

see coworkers who are always late as people who aren't dependable (or even lazy), but other coworkers or friends may be able to help them see past their preconceived notions. Those "always late" coworkers may be single parents in charge of dropping kids off at school before work and may not have help. Tapping into their innate compassion by learning more about their coworkers' history helps Defenders empathize with those who may not meet their high personal expectations.

Finding Healthy Ways to De-Stress

Similarly, learning how to decompress or deal with unexpected changes in the workplace is vital for Defenders' well-being. While they aren't naïve enough to believe things will always go as expected, these types may struggle to recover from stressful situations. Five to ten minutes of deep breathing and intentional relaxation after awkward encounters with coworkers can provide the calming stability they need. Daily exercise – such as walking, yoga, swimming, biking, or hiking – also improves physical, mental, and emotional health, especially for individuals with stressful occupations.

These activities also provide Defenders with an opportunity to practice mindfulness and gain mental clarity by causing them to focus on physical activity. "Getting out of their heads" for even a short while may prevent these types from dwelling on the negative aspects of their work and provide momentary peace of mind.

Jobs and Skill Sets

Let's look at some specific jobs that Defenders may find fit them best. Rather than attempt the impossible and list every job that might suit these types, we offer a sampling of jobs that are compatible with

Defender personality traits, and offer explanations for why, that they can use when considering their career goals.

For those already employed, this may serve as a confirmation or explanation for how happy or unhappy Defenders are in their line of work. We don't presume this to be a firm prescription of what must be done to be successful or happy. Rather, we hope it provides some insight as personal decisions are made.

Business and Logistics

Having something or someone you need at the right place and the right time is the heart and soul of logistics and management. There's perhaps no better personality Role than Sentinels for carrying out this important work. Defenders are sticklers for the details needed to get things right and are more likely than others to catch discrepancies. Beyond a doubt, those who cross all the "T"s and dot all the "I"s are of great value in any office. Any analyses Defenders make are likely to be fact-based and according to the rules, thus ensuring accuracy.

Defenders are warm individuals who are most likely to remember colleagues' birthdays and the names of their family members. These types enjoy working in cooperative setting with friendly and equally hard-working coworkers. Defenders don't, however, enjoy competitive, aggressive environments and would likely fare poorly in jobs that focus on high-pressure sales or an ultra-competitive growth mentality. Helping people while also carrying out important, well-defined work is ideal for this personality type. Employment in the fields of business or logistics that may best utilize Defenders' qualities might include:

- Office manager
- Paralegal or legal assistant
- Customer advocate
- Human resources
- Teller or loan officer
- Shop or small business owner
- Internal help desk

Health Care

At the core of most Sentinels, including Defenders, is the need to take care of others in tangible, practical ways. This makes them excellent candidates for health care work. Their traits explicitly equip them to care for patients, especially their attention to detail, organizational focus, and ability to meet goals. Defender health workers typically won't tolerate negligence or mistakes, making them invaluable in medical settings. People with this personality type are warm, but also all business. They work well in small groups or teams, especially the well-functioning ones necessary in health care settings. Jobs that may fit them well include:

- Family physician
- Nurse
- Dentist
- Medical secretary
- Physical therapist
- Dietitian
- Speech pathologist
- Patient advocate

Education

In elementary education, and in courses that involve teaching practical skills, Defenders make excellent teachers. "No child left behind," which was the motto of an education movement, is a marching order for Sentinel teachers, and Defenders in particular have the internal motivation necessary to help children progress as they should both individually and as a group. They tend to genuinely care whether their students learn or not.

These types function best with younger children who need instruction involving rudimentary skill building. They may do well teaching older students if the courses involve building a skill, such as computer programming, second languages, or automobile mechanics. They're also perhaps the best type for collecting and organizing raw data for

research projects at universities. Education jobs for Defenders might include:

- Elementary school teacher
- Auto mechanic or shop teacher
- Economics or home economics teacher
- Life skills teacher (including adult education courses in these skills)
- Coach (any sport or skilled-based activity)
- History, art history, or literature teacher
- School principal (if the job's not too political)
- Early childhood educator
- Day care provider or nanny

Challenging Career Qualities

In modern society, people not only spend lots of time at work, but they also tend to want their jobs to give them meaning. A career that isn't suitable for one's personality type can lead to extraordinary difficulties in achieving happiness or fulfillment. The following paragraphs contain some characteristics of the kinds of job that may not be suitable for Defenders.

Loose Structure

Defenders tend to need a strong sense of structure to feel at ease in their positions. They respect the authority of the boss, the reliability of their colleagues or subordinates, and the sovereignty of time-honored rules. Explicit hierarchies and chains of command provide these types with the sense there's a solid foundation holding everything up.

These types don't like improvised action or taking unproven paths. They need to feel they have a firm foothold in a company, but they won't if the ground is continuously shifting. In a company culture too forgiving of mistakes, which are sometimes the results of useful risks, these types may feel out of place. To succeed, Defenders demand a tight ship.

Lack of Appreciation

Defenders enjoy others appreciating the work they do. They may not be obvious about it, but more than other types, Defenders need some positive acknowledgment for their undertakings. It could be a monetary reward or only a heartfelt thank you, but they need a signal that their work is necessary and appreciated. People with this personality type are unlikely to overtly advertise their accomplishments, and may instead employ passive-aggressive behaviors to show their frustration or disappointment.

Defenders should investigate potential places of employment for a positive, responsible environment. Scan the room to see if employees are smiling and interacting in kind, respectful ways. Research the company to see if they're living up to their mission statement and values. Check to see if performance-based raises, 401k matching, or other benefits are offered that show dedication to their employees. Companies with a positive environment and employee benefits are the most likely to show appreciation and respect to their work force.

Work That's Aggressive or Confrontational

Defenders thrive on helping people and work well with others. However, there are some careers where interaction with others isn't always ideal. Specifically, careers that focus on high-pressured sales, like used-car sales, or those that are commission-based are likely to repel most Defenders. While this has been touched on in previous sections, it's worth a deeper look.

Fields that are highly competitive, pitting one employee against another, are off-putting to Defenders seeking a cooperative workplace. Similarly, those companies that put profits ahead of customer needs won't appeal to Defenders who are looking to help others, not cheat them out of their hard-earned money.

Career Alternatives

Anything Is Possible

This may seem radical, but people don't need to be employed in the traditional sense to live comfortably. We live in an age of possibilities, and selling one's time to a corporation isn't the only way to generate

income. Defenders are hardworking, diligent individuals, and their impressive ability to remember copious amounts of facts can be very valuable. Why not try turning them into an opportunity for self-employment?

Self-Employment

Defenders may find the notion of self-employment quite scary. However, the time when someone could spend twenty or more years working at the same company and feeling secure in that future are largely over. Job security and guaranteed prospects are a thing of the past, except for select fields such as accounting or medicine.

Consequently, working for themselves may be a more secure and viable option. Defenders value respect, control, and self-reliance, and being self-employed can provide excellent opportunities to enjoy these things.

Furthermore, self-employment solves several major hurdles Defenders are likely to encounter in the corporate environment. As self-employed individuals, Defenders are free to choose which tasks they want to perform and which ones they want to delegate or outsource – no more following irrational orders or dealing with people who are more interested in play than work.

Self-employment may offer the ability to work from home as another significant benefit to Defenders, allowing them to spend more time with family (especially children) while still maintaining or expanding their sources of income.

Professional Volunteer

A bold and inspiring para-career option for Defenders is that of professional volunteer – making income second to their loftier goals of helping others. While financial prosperity may be off the table, unparalleled personal satisfaction and growth are attainable in its place. If supported by income from other endeavors, or even supportive partners or spouses, Defenders who devote themselves entirely to conscientious progress can move mountains. This is also a role these types can transition into later in life, bringing skill sets from previous occupations into the nonprofit world with expert vigor.

For example, Defenders with any level of medical training can easily find roles within international aid organizations. They can have their basic needs met while they volunteer to provide training, education, and health care to those in extreme need.

Experienced or educated Defenders can probably find a need for their abilities and knowledge regardless of their background, especially if they're willing to travel – anyone from welders and carpenters to teachers and gardeners are useful to many of these organizations.

If Defenders want to offer such help, the least developed countries are extremely hungry for compassion, dedication, and boots on the ground. Any skills and knowledge can be of use when driven by this personality type's burning desire to help. A resume of abilities with a passionate cover letter may allow Defenders to enter many different organizations as volunteers. If they can accept potentially austere material lives, the rewards to their souls can be infinite.

However, foreign aid work and a monastic lifestyle aren't mandatory – there are many volunteer opportunities for Defenders within more developed countries. For starters, administrative and fundraising roles abound at the headquarters of idealistic organizations, from grassroots political groups to religious and secular charities. They'll embrace the willing hands, heart, and voice of any enthusiastic Defenders who want to pitch in – and the appreciation they'll receive feels amazing.

Defenders who find large organizations unappealing can create their own small groups, or even act individually. Something as basic as tutoring younger children in reading and math can be done by almost anyone with warmth, patience, and a high school education, and can make an incredible difference in a child's future.

Another example could be self-organized campaigns on social media, allowing Defenders to advocate for whatever they consider necessary. Successful efforts may draw in other volunteers, or even establish partnerships with other groups or larger charities.

Defenders can find a path of volunteerism as dramatic as spending a year abroad as aid workers, or as simple as sitting in their kitchens making phone calls to grocery stores to organize food bank donations.

Regardless of the scale or complexity, commitment to volunteerism may be one of the best ways for Defenders to satisfy their desire to create harmony and healing in the world. They can dip their toes in while keeping their day jobs – or plunge into the deep end and devote their time fully to helping others.

For Defenders, the psychological and spiritual rewards of volunteerism can make up for the lack of compensation, and distinguishing themselves through their dedication and proficiency may even lead to long-term, paying positions. Defenders may find this path is worth serious consideration.

Workplace Cooperation Between Roles

Professional development isn't complicated: it's a combination of personal awareness and changes in behavior following this awareness that takes place along the career path. Understanding one's strengths, weaknesses, values, and goals is necessary to become the best employee, manager, or volunteer possible.

Defenders don't necessarily need a "special" environment to make their work satisfying. And, while they truly enjoy working behind the scenes, they make excellent managers and leaders as well. The real key to making sure Defenders succeed in any role is understanding themselves and knowing their goals.

The following paragraphs discuss the potential issues and opportunities these types may face when dealing with colleagues in each of the different personality type Roles (Analysts, Diplomats, Sentinels, and Explorers).

Defender–Analyst Cooperation

Defenders' and Analysts' most powerful shared trait is the need for workplace efficiency. Analysts use systems to make them run smoothly. Defenders do the same with more practical matters, such as bringing order to an organization's tasks. Each type plays a different role when they have jobs that suit them in an organization.

Balanced Cooperation

Efficient and Effective

Defender–Analyst relationships are mutually beneficial, with Analysts developing ideas, plans, and systems, and Defenders providing reality checks, organizing, and implementing these visions. Analysts may be masters at innovative ideas, but they need someone else around to turn them into something practical. Defenders are great at getting things done. In many ways, they're a perfect match.

From such examples, it's easy to assume Defenders are always subordinate to visionary Analysts. However, consider Analysts in research positions with Defender bosses – it's the opposite power relationship, yet they complement each other's roles just the same. Regardless of their workplace titles, by clearly understanding and accepting each other's roles and communicating from their positions of strength, each type can become invaluable to the other.

Improving Attitudes

Defenders tend to be the epitome of humility, and many Analysts could stand to take a page or two from their playbook on how to be humble. Analysts often come to respect (and hopefully try to

emulate) the competence and modesty of their Defender colleagues. Also, Defenders are compassionate and considerate of others – skills Analysts can benefit from improving as well, and Defenders are more than happy to assist them.

Defenders, on the other hand, can at times get stuck in a relatively narrow way of thinking. For them, things are either right or wrong, black or white, and not necessarily open to new interpretations. Analysts are excellent at "thinking outside the box" and viewing challenges as opportunities. In the workplace, they can encourage and inspire their Defender colleagues to consider different options they wouldn't have normally considered.

Unbalanced Cooperation

Maintaining versus Innovating

There's an old saying, "Nobody likes change except a wet baby." While whole industries have grown up around "change management," it's not true that "nobody likes change." Intuitive types like Analysts and Diplomats love change. They crave it, as it represents growth and possibilities to them, and they always look for ideas to improve things.

On the other hand, Defenders focus more on doing the right thing according to proven standards and traditions. They have an inherent fear of change, an instability found in unfamiliar situations or circumstances. Big changes carry big risks, and this type of uncertainty doesn't bode well for stability-craving Defenders. They aren't likely to aggressively oppose Analysts pushing their innovative ideas, but it may be difficult for them to support them if they aren't backed up by evidence of their potential success. This may frustrate Analysts, who may view their lack of support as an inability to see "the big picture" or even "simple-minded" stubbornness.

Passive-Aggressive versus Confident

The universal conflict between those trying to preserve a system and those trying to change it is perhaps as old as humanity itself. It's a difficult area in the workplace that may play out as passive-aggressive resistance or discounting the importance of other's contributions. Defenders'

and Analysts' diverse approaches need careful communication, reassurances, and much understanding.

Analysts' social style may lack warmth and consideration for the emotional needs of others. Workplace conversations with these types can quickly take on an assertive tone, especially when they're defending their opinions. Debaters – the opposite personality type of Defenders – not only enjoy confrontational discussions, they actively seek them out. This aggressive style of communication is likely to repel Defenders, who may avoid interactions with them whenever possible.

Defenders, on the other hand, may go so far out of their way to avoid conflict that they fail to express their opinions at all. Instead, they may imply their frustrations with passive-aggressive behaviors such as exceptional stubbornness or avoiding tasks they don't support. Defenders would never go so far as to shirk their responsibilities. However, they won't jump at the opportunity to assist with projects or ideas they disagree with.

Rebalancing Cooperation

Practicing Positive Communication

Thankfully, Defenders often go out of their way to ensure they work as well as possible with colleagues. Analysts aren't detail-oriented, and may not even realize the amount of work that goes into certain tasks. While they may not receive the appreciation that they deserve (or desire) from Analyst counterparts, Defenders take pleasure in knowing Analyst coworkers benefit from their stability and attention to detail, even if they don't always recognize it. But Defenders shouldn't hesitate to communicate their needs and expectations as well. Here are some ways they can approach this.

- Analysts may expect an idea to be implemented without consulting Defender colleagues about what may be required to complete their tasks. They may have an unrealistic time frame or unreasonable expectations, not knowing what details are involved in the actual implementation of an idea.

- Defenders can ask questions about specific details, such as who should do the work, how long the work should take, and what should happen to other deadlines and priorities. These questions call attention to the level of detail and thought that's necessary for Defenders to complete the tasks without resulting in unwanted confrontation.
- Empathy and emotional control aren't developed skills for most Analysts, and they're unlikely to realize when they're hurtful or offensive. Defenders are wonderful models for positive social interaction and can help "teach" Analysts how to interact in a more considerate way.
- By learning not to take criticism or harsh comments from Analysts to heart, Defenders can let them know they're crossing a line in a compassionate and diplomatic way.
- If all else fails with overly critical or hurtful Analysts, calling in the support of coworkers or managers who are more comfortable with confrontation (or are the Analysts' managers) is a safe, effective way of addressing such situations.

Defender–Diplomat Cooperation

Both Defenders and Diplomats like to take care of other people and promote the human side of their work. While Diplomats focus more on ideological compassion, Defenders' interests lie more in taking care of others on a more practical level. For example, Defenders might want to make sure they complete the payroll, so everyone receives their salary. Meanwhile, Diplomats might focus on making sure that everyone receives fair treatment and professional development opportunities. Both find energy and self-respect in doing good for others and share plenty of common ground on which to bond.

Balanced Cooperation

Macro and Micro Visions

Defenders and Diplomats complement each other by providing different kinds of support for the organization. For Diplomats, it's the larger picture and the big ideas that are important. They're interested in growth for themselves and others. Defenders are interested in doing what's best for individuals in their workplace. Together, these two types tend to push workplace options that provide professional growth and meet such practical needs as health care benefits and time-off policies.

Partnering with Diplomats can help Defenders hold on to the greater vision of an organization. Defenders can help to ground the idealistic plans that Diplomats put forward with much-needed pragmatism. Inspired by Diplomat colleagues' grand ideas to make the workplace (and the world) better, Defenders' attention to detail can help their shared desire for cooperation and compassion for all become a reality.

Unbalanced Cooperation

Realistic versus Idealistic

Conflict arises when Defenders are too pragmatic, or Diplomats are too idealistic. If some arrive 10 minutes early for work and others arrive 10 minutes late, you can almost guess which are Defenders and which are Diplomats. It won't be because Diplomats thumb their noses at the rules or time clocks – it's just that those 10 minutes aren't as high on their mental list of priorities. However, that might be hard to explain to Defender supervisors who find comfort in enforcing the rules. It can become difficult to bridge this gap in attitudes and behaviors.

To Defenders, Diplomats may appear to pursue actions or ideas on a whim without considering consequences or logistics. They don't realize the subconscious linking of information or feelings that have taken place that leads to their decisions. Defenders, on the other hand, may come across to their Diplomat colleagues as overly focused on details and unwilling to consider the overall "big picture."

Personal Growth or Practical Needs?

Individuals – whether employees, customers, patients or students – are the most important part of any workplace for both Diplomats and Defenders. Their ideas of what's needed to support these individuals, however, may differ. Defenders tend to believe that a work environment provides services for both employees and the individuals that utilize their services. For example, a school serves to educate students and provides satisfying jobs for teachers with, ideally, sufficient pay and benefits.

Diplomats believe the workplace should provide opportunities for everyone impacted by their services. For example, a school should prepare students to engage in careers or activities that create a better future, and provide personal and professional growth opportunities for its employees as well. Merely "educating" students wouldn't necessarily go far enough – and pay and benefits are secondary to the fulfillment of the employees' potential.

Defenders believe that the practical needs of all individuals must be met for everyone to benefit. Diplomats are likely to feel that merely meeting practical needs doesn't go nearly far enough. These differences can cause conflict when either type is convinced that theirs is the "correct" or more noble view.

Rebalancing Cooperation

Find Shared Values

One good thing about Defenders and Diplomats is that they both prefer to foster positive relationships in the workplace and engage in a non-confrontational way. In that sense, Defenders can expect their Diplomat colleagues to willingly participate in any rebalancing efforts. Specifically, Defenders may work on connecting with Diplomats on an empathetic level. Finding shared values, such as promoting the well-being of the company, or fighting for a client who needs their help, is likely more effective than trying to get them on board with following the "rules."

Defenders usually find Diplomat colleagues willing to discuss ways to work together in more positive and efficient ways. In explaining their

concerns about an idea in their naturally compassionate way, Diplomats will likely provide them with as many facts and details as possible. Diplomats are also likely to seek out Defenders to help them fill in any gaps in their plans or ideas that they may not have considered. These personality types can resolve any potential problems by understanding that both their world views (and skill sets) have something valuable to offer.

Engage in Mutual Encouragement

Despite their different workplace priorities, Defenders and Diplomats are appreciative of anyone who is looking to make improvements on behalf of people. In a world where there's such an extreme focus on profits, productivity, and power, there doesn't seem to be as much concern about the people being affected by these systems. Working together, these types can improve the workplace for themselves as well as for others by keeping the following in mind.

- Both Diplomats and Defenders are likely to benefit from focusing on encouraging each other and supporting each other's work.
- Defenders, in their focus on practical needs, may ask Diplomats deeper questions about their ideas to ensure practical aspects are covered.
- Having a realistic timeline, adequate funding, and a manageable workload may all be considerations that are evident to Defenders but potentially overlooked by Diplomats.
- Similarly, Defenders can benefit from listening to the creative, thoughtful components of their Diplomat colleagues' ideas.

Defender–Sentinel Cooperation

Defender and Sentinel colleagues tend to find themselves "speaking the same language." They're both about getting the job done, and it's often the main thrust of their conversations. This doesn't mean that people belonging to these types won't engage in casual conversation, but their motivation to do so is likely be to create harmony in the workplace. They're both often sincerely warm and personable. However, when it's time to go to work, there can be a no-nonsense quality to their conversations.

Balanced Cooperation

Pragmatic and Personable

Defenders are pragmatists, and with Sentinel coworkers, they can avoid the abstract, theoretical discussions Analysts and Diplomats tend to cover. Discussions among Defenders and other Sentinels focus on facts and procedures. They embrace tradition and linking the past with the future.

Sentinels, especially Defenders, are nurturers who take care of other people. They try to make others' lives easier through establishing satisfying outcomes for everyone involved. They tend to ensure that every possibility toward that end is considered, spending most of their time going over logistics and organization to ensure everything runs smoothly.

Unbalanced Cooperation

Differing Agendas

Despite their similarities, Defenders may find themselves disagreeing with Sentinel colleagues who differ in their approach. For example, Executives may come across as brash and confrontational, which is very unappealing to conflict-averse Defenders. While both types are focused on getting things done efficiently, Defenders want to make sure that the people involved are being treated fairly throughout the process. Executive managers may push colleagues to stay late to finish a project, whereas Defender managers are more likely to delay a project's completion to allow employees to spend time with their families.

Logisticians can also frustrate Defender colleagues with their unwillingness to compromise and focus on productivity over people. Following rules and procedures is the most important priority for Logisticians, while Defenders are more concerned with making sure that such rules and procedures benefit the individuals most affected by them. Defenders can become disheartened by Logisticians' lack of compassion and may struggle to find acceptable common ground when working with them.

Uncomfortable with Change

The problems Sentinels may have working together most likely have nothing to do with whether they understand each other. However, they may have trouble if they become stuck in their own style of thinking without the benefit of insight from those who think differently. In business and life, it's good to have varied personality types around to provide balance and promote inclusivity.

Discussions of extensive innovation and change may also be unsettling for Defenders, who revere traditional ways of doing things. Sentinels bear their name for a reason – they protect what they value, take care of others, and prefer a fixed way of doing things. They serve as the anchors needed in a stable society. However, the world is a rapidly changing place, and often organizations need to innovate to compete. "Thinking outside of the box" is an overused cliché, but it's being so ubiquitous shows how important thinking in new ways has become.

For Defenders and other Sentinels, such challenges to the confines of the proverbial box may feel almost like an affront. They spend a lot of time protecting systems that work, and they're likely to feel uncomfortable if these systems are questioned. To balance these concerns, they can invite other personality types to the table when discussing the development of new products or systems.

Rebalancing Cooperation

Focusing on Common Ground

Despite their different approaches, Defenders tend to find cooperation easier with other Sentinels when they focus on their common goals. As a particularly cooperative type, Defenders are in a prime position to bridge any gaps in understanding with their rational, compassionate dialogue. For example, Defenders can appeal to Executives by articulating that employee productivity is better when there's a proper work-home life balance.

Defenders can also provide examples of how to complete tasks efficiently and effectively while still taking the human factor into account. These are valuable lesson for Logisticians who may not realize it's possible to be a productive employee while still considering the needs of others.

Sharing the Load

Much can be said for having allies in the workplace, especially those who share the same views and behaviors. It's especially important for Defenders to find some like-minded colleagues they can trust and "Share the Load with," as Defender Samwise Gamgee from Tolkien's *The Lord of the Rings* would say. Defenders may face some genuine challenges if they're too insistent on maintaining an unrealistic workload and refusing to delegate.

Defenders should be particularly aware of potential control issues they and their Sentinel colleagues may face. It's important to understand that their ultimate goals are probably the same in most situations – and there's almost always more than one way to achieve them. There are situations where it's more important to get things done or maintain the peace than to do them in a particular manner. It's important for Defenders to be able to identify these situations.

Defender–Explorer Cooperation

It's easy to get the impression that Defenders and Explorers are complete opposites. While they often approach things differently, both types gather their information from the world around them instead of more internal, intuitive sources like Analysts or Diplomats.

However, that's where most of their similarities end. While Explorers are more in touch with things directly and immediately, Defenders usually filter their experiences through what they remember and how things have always been. Explorers relish the new and exciting, while Defenders favor the safe and stable. Despite these differences, they both speak in terms of what is practical and tangible, as opposed to the more ambiguous or abstract dialogue favored by Intuitive types.

Balanced Cooperation

Practical and Tangible

Explorers and Defenders most often complement each other when things go wrong. Sometimes even the tried-and-true ways of doing things fail, and while this can be disconcerting to Defenders, it's a compelling problem to solve for Explorers. In this ever-changing world, there are times when the old methods no longer work. There may be no other choice than to develop a new way of doing things, and Explorers' hands-on, solutions-oriented approach can help Defenders make sense of many new, challenging situations.

A Reliable Home Base for Explorative Types

On the other hand, sometimes Explorers' impulsive drive to find solutions can go off-track. Occasionally, the best answer when a situation goes bad is to retreat to a known starting place. "Known places" are where Defenders like to spend their time. As Explorers get older, they may seek out Sentinel marriage partners to help them settle down. It also makes sense that this could apply to professional situations.

There are times when boldly "winging" it can lead to effective solutions. However, there are also times when such approaches create more problems than they solve. Sometimes Defenders can help Explorers "come home," figuratively speaking. Defenders usually know how to repair a situation (or they know someone who does). This can be of great help to Explorers who have wandered too far in the wrong direction.

Unbalanced Cooperation

Differences in Discipline

While Explorers have no problem cutting corners when necessary, Defenders usually dedicate their lives to making sure those corners remain pristine and intact. Explorers tend to have a freer attitude and love things that are new and interesting. Defenders may have a favorite restaurant they go to most of the time, while Explorers may want to sample all the latest restaurants in town.

Entrepreneurs, with their loose ethics and brazen focus on action over substance, are particularly likely to frustrate and offend morally conscious Defenders. Actions are symbolic of beliefs, and Defenders believe in fairness for all people. For Explorers, especially Entrepreneurs, actions are primarily based on their individual, often spontaneous, desires. They aren't necessarily uncaring toward others, but fairness may be viewed by these types as weakness or a lack of ability to protect or promote their own interests and well-being.

This isn't true of all Explorers – especially those with the Feeling trait, who are much less likely to focus on this type of self-promotion. Defenders may likely find communication with Adventurers and Entertainers more

relatable, and may struggle with open and honest communication with seemingly less-compassionate Virtuosos or Entrepreneurs.

Stability Meets Spontaneity

While stability seems essential to Defenders, Explorers have no problem doing whatever they need to do to solve a problem regardless of "how it's always been done." Defenders see the tried-and-true means as the way to a guaranteed end. Only the end concerns Explorers, and they may use any means necessary to get there. For them, it doesn't have to follow traditional protocol.

It's easy to see how Defenders can view Explorers as being at cross-purposes with them. Defenders may devote an undue amount of time trying to get Explorers to walk in a straight line according to the rules. Meanwhile, Explorers may ignore Defenders and do whatever they think it takes – whether going in a straight line or serpentine – to master a situation. The possibilities for conflicts between these personality types are endless.

Rebalancing Cooperation

Embracing and Appreciating Differences

Improving cooperation between Defenders and Explorers is the ultimate balancing act. Here are some things Defenders can keep in mind as they approach the high wire at work.

- Defenders, for their part, need to embrace the idea that each personality type brings their own unique set of skills and abilities to the workplace. While everyone needs to follow the rules, continuously playing the role of "rules police" may be more trouble than it's worth if Explorers are contributing in positive ways.
- In the same vein, a little acknowledgment can go a long way with Explorers, and Defenders should make sure that they show appreciation for the good things that Explorers do. They're likely to reciprocate this by acknowledging the good work that Defenders do as well.

- Defender's ability to provide stability is of significant importance for Explorers, as they're the most likely to go off the tracks and give into their impulses. While they may initially find this behavior tedious or unnecessary, Explorers are likely to come to appreciate (and rely on) their Defender colleague's reliability when they've ventured too far off course.
- The dependability and support that Defenders provide is vital for any workplace, but especially so when there are Explorers in the company as well.
- At the same time, much can be said for adventuring outside of one's comfort zone. Most growth, both professional and personal, comes from challenging or unique experiences. Defenders who want to grow would do well to seek out Explorers to help them test their boundaries.
- Volunteering for a project that they wouldn't typically become involved in, partnering with Explorers on a task they would normally do themselves, or even just seeking out advice or a new perspective from Explorer colleagues can provide valuable insight and promote positive cooperation.

Conclusion

Defenders often express their strength by quietly enduring hardship, determinedly preserving structure, and selflessly taking care of others. However, one of the most critical things for these types to prioritize is self-care, including the wise realization that what's most beneficial isn't always what's most comfortable. Sometimes, difficult choices bring great happiness and success, whether it's embracing useful changes, communicating needs confidently, or preserving enough time and energy for personal goals. Such things aren't selfish, and ensuring their own well-being and satisfaction only enhances what Defenders can offer others.

Final Words

The Road Ahead

In a world where all too many people seem to feel entitled to attention and success, Defenders are a breath of fresh air. Humble and hardworking, Defenders are willing to put in the hours, start with the fundamentals, and deliver on their commitments ¬– all while helping others along the way. Diligent students and industrious workers, Defenders consistently prove the value of persistence and hard work.

In many cases, this approach produces the results that matter to Defenders: stability, security, and the satisfaction of a job well done. But at some point, pretty much every Defender will encounter a teacher or boss who doesn't communicate clear expectations, a colleague who takes credit for their work, or a situation that requires a fresh approach rather than more effort – challenges that are more than a little uncomfortable for Defenders.

Our hope is that these pages have affirmed for Defenders the value of their steady, humble approach to learning and work, while also proving that there's no need for them to have their contributions go unrecognized or for them to work themselves to the point of exhaustion. Instead, it's by quietly asserting themselves, expanding their comfort zones, and recognizing their own value that Defenders can stave off burnout and find long-term satisfaction and fulfillment in their studies and their work.

So... What's Next?

You've reached the end of this book, but fear not – we've created many more resources for you. Here are a few that might capture your interest:

- Want more tests and insights to help you excel in your career? Explore our Career Tools and Assessments.
- Looking to enhance your relationships? Check out the *Defender Guide to Relationships*.
- Ready to build a strong foundation for your self-development? Our *Defender Guide to Personal Growth* may be just what you need.

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